This Little Snake Rolls Like a Wheel to Escape

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Snakes have many ways to stay safe. Some bite, and some **rattle** their tails. But the dwarf reed snake from Southeast Asia has a surprising trick. When it is in danger, it rolls away like a wheel!

This snake is usually less than 12 inches long. When it rolls, it can move about one foot every second. That is about four times faster than when it **slithers**. It can even roll in a straight line while keeping its head **steady**.

Scientists at Toho University in Japan filmed the snakes with **high-speed cameras**. These cameras show fast moves in **slow motion**. The scientists found that the snake whips one side of its body forward, then the other side, again and again.

It is a little like twirling a rope while holding one end still. For this snake, the end that stays still is its head. That way, it can keep looking ahead while it zooms away.

Word Treasure

rattle -- To shake something so it makes a quick clicking or buzzing sound.

slithers -- Moves by sliding and twisting along the ground, like most snakes.

steady -- Still and not shaking or wobbling.

high-speed cameras -- Cameras that take many pictures very fast so you can watch actions in slow motion.

slow motion -- When a video plays much slower than real life so you can see quick moves.

Background you need

Most snakes move by sliding their long bodies across the ground.

Small animals often have special tricks to get away from animals that want to eat them.

Scientists film fast animals so they can watch each move up close.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists at Toho University in Japan and the dwarf reed snake
WHAT: The snake rolls like a wheel to escape danger
WHERE: The snake lives in Southeast Asia
WHY: Rolling helps it get away about four times faster than slithering

Why it matters

It shows that animals can surprise us, so it is fun to watch nature closely and ask how things work.

Test what you remember

1. What does the dwarf reed snake do when it is in danger?

- (A) It hides in a shell
- (B) It flies
- (C) It rolls away like a wheel
- (D) It swims

2. Where does this snake come from?

- (A) The North Pole
- (B) Mars
- (C) Antarctica
- (D) Southeast Asia

3. How long is the snake usually?

- (A) About 12 feet
- (B) One mile
- (C) As long as a bus
- (D) Less than 12 inches

4. How much faster is rolling than slithering?

- (A) The same
- (B) Half as fast
- (C) 100 times faster
- (D) About four times faster

5. What did scientists use to study the snakes?

- (A) Magnets
- (B) Telescopes
- (C) High-speed cameras
- (D) Ice

6. Which part of the snake stays still while it rolls?

- (A) Its tail
- (B) Its head
- (C) Its belly
- (D) Nothing

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: D 4: D 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):